

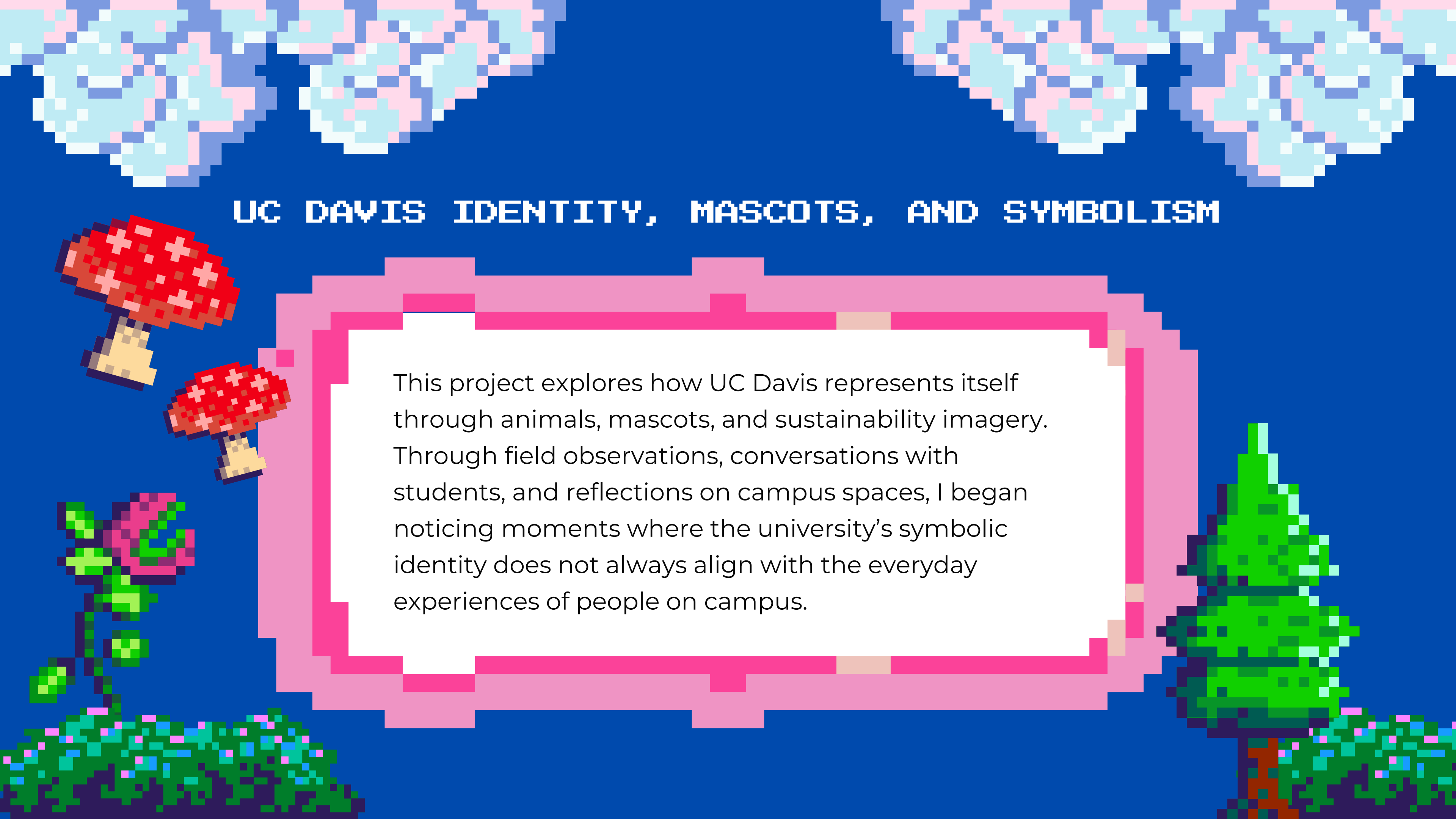


CONSTRUCTING CAMPUS IDENTITY

DES126: A Design Ethnographic Portfolio

START

BY : CAROLINE CHEN



UC DAVIS IDENTITY, MASCOTS, AND SYMBOLISM

This project explores how UC Davis represents itself through animals, mascots, and sustainability imagery. Through field observations, conversations with students, and reflections on campus spaces, I began noticing moments where the university's symbolic identity does not always align with the everyday experiences of people on campus.

ethnography → controversial history, debatable definition
study of collection with ethical practices; what is considered ethical?

- how do you observe w/o interference?
- History of colonization → forcing modernity
- Can you define moral code? Does it vary amongst researchers?

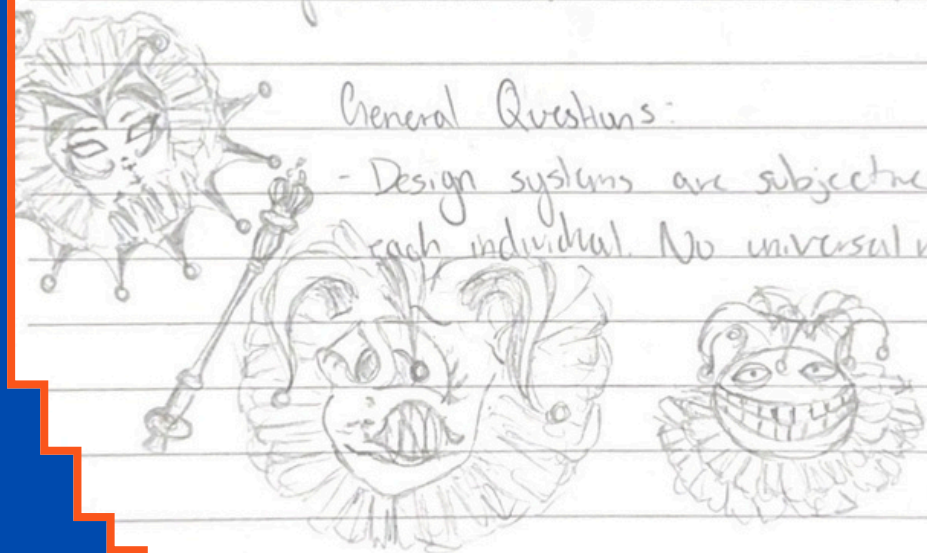
Mascots - Is it an identity or an actual being?

→ Statefarm is Khakis's red shirt (Does this count?)

- Not always fictional (Think Steve Jobs as Face of Apple)

General Questions:

- Design systems are subjective to each individual. No universal method.

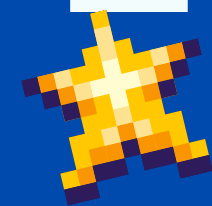


INITIAL UNDERSTANDING OF ETHNOGRAPHY

Before taking this class, I did not fully understand what ethnography meant. I had heard the term before, but I mostly thought of it as observation or research in general. As the quarter progressed, I began realizing that ethnography focuses much more on relationships and interpretation. It requires paying attention to environments, conversations, and the small details that shape how people experience a place.

A former Design 126 student who visited our class described **research as recursive rather than linear**. The more information you gather, the more questions begin to appear. That idea stayed with me throughout the project.





PHASE I. ETHICS TOOLKIT



The first phase of the project focused on developing ethical guidelines for fieldwork. My group focused on inclusivity and consent. We discussed how participation in research should be grounded in trust, collaboration, and mutual respect between researchers and participants.

One principle we developed stated:

“Validation of any participatory efforts will be held to the same standards with permission of consent. All involved individuals are subject to a relationship built on trust, collaboration, and integrity.”



- Who benefits ~ community
- Consent (participant inclusion)
- cultural inclusivity
- preventing harm/harassment
- avoid assumptions/stereotypes
- privacy
 - careful w/ ppl's contact info
- How to not mislead participants
- Accessibility
 - modifying values/processes based on participatory critique
 - modify according to the course of the process (accountability)
- remove bias

79%

promote inclusivity and diversity, all entering individuals' input will be held to the same standards with documented proof of consent.

⇒ VALID

- not speaking to any "one" person
- consider protection of studio members as well
- consent (situation-based) should not always be documented for the sake of privacy
 - what if participant is in dangerous situation (verbal consent, needs trust) → "where applicable"
 - "when safe for participants"
- (conducive to trust), we will seek...
- transparency for assignments

90%

built on trust, collaboration, and integrity.

Today, we refined our ethics in application to field work. As a class, we developed 10-11 principles. As a group, we focused on the topics of inclusivity & consent.

The idea of documented consent became a question of trust and safety. In some cases, participants could face backlash or persecution for their involvement, so undocumented or verbal consent is important. The bounds of these principles change depending on the context of the study, but the general mindset & values of a trust that goes both ways, stays consistent.

100%

After speaking with Professor Arbona-Homar, I also learned that consent is not always something that can be formally documented. In certain situations written consent can actually create risks for participants, meaning verbal trust and understanding may be more appropriate depending on the context.

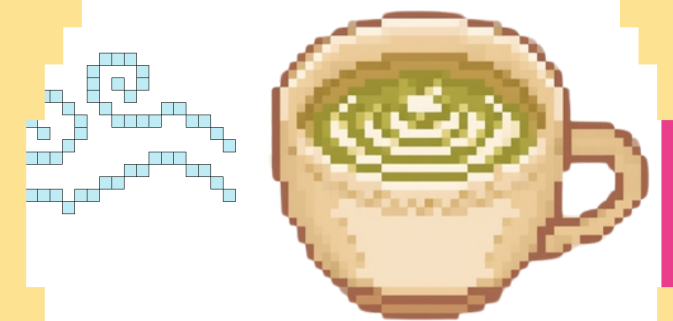
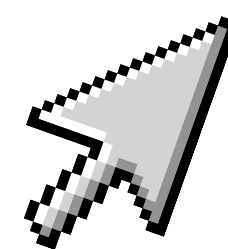
PHASE 2: FIELDWORK

The second phase of the project focused on ethnographic fieldwork. Our goal was to observe different areas of campus and speak with students about how they perceive UC Davis identity.

At first, these places seemed unrelated, but as observations and conversations accumulated, connections between them slowly began to appear.

Some of the main locations we visited:

- **UC Davis Equestrian Center**
- **The Silo and Gunrock restaurant**
- **The Sheep Mowers mural**



EQUESTRIAN CENTER VISIT



One of our first visits was to the UC Davis Equestrian Center. The facility has existed since the 1960s and currently houses around seventy-six horses. Observing the horses made it clear how individualized they are. They can be differentiated by their fur color, behavior, and temperament. Staff explained that bonding with horses requires routine, patience, and consistency.



During the visit, we also learned that the women's equestrian team will no longer compete as a varsity sport after this quarter. Some of the horses currently housed there may need to be relocated. For a university that celebrates Gunrock as its horse mascot, this raised questions about how certain traditions are preserved while others slowly disappear.

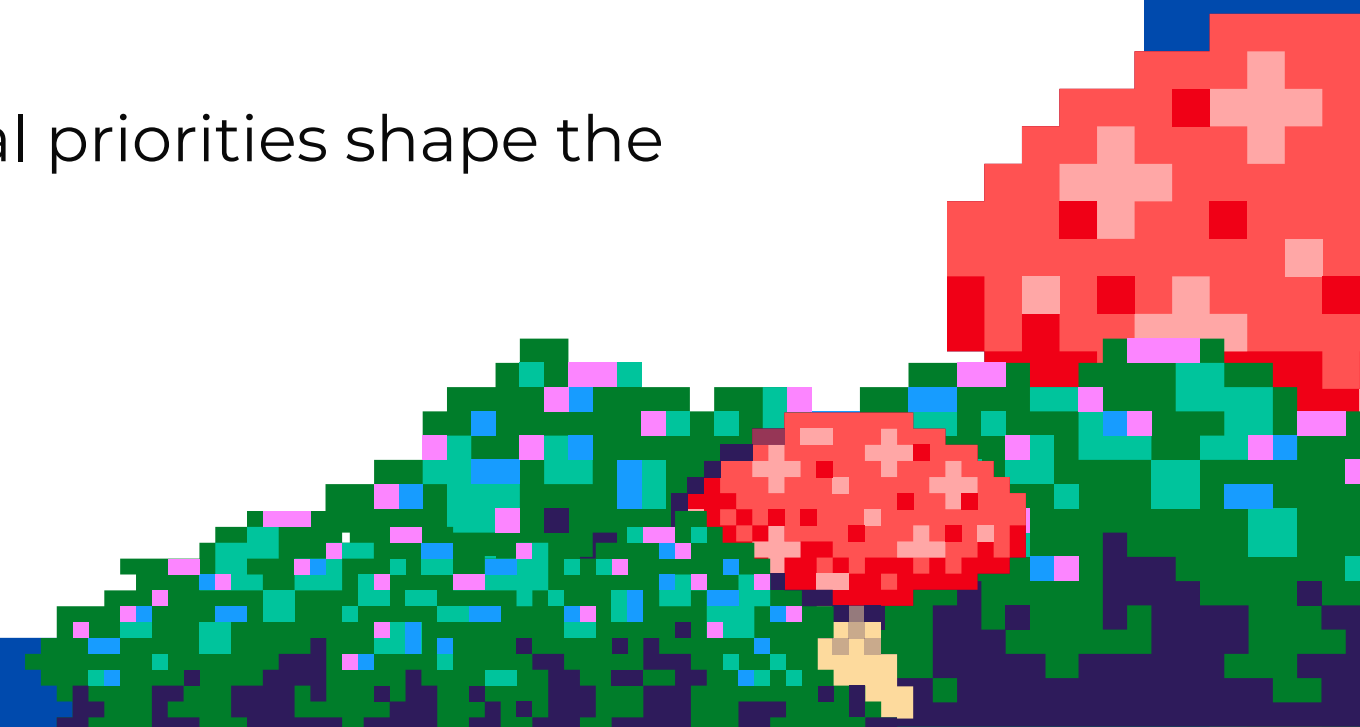


PHASE 2 THEMES: EQUESTRIAN CENTER



Several themes began to emerge from this visit:

- There appears to be a disconnect between how UC Davis represents its heritage and how certain programs are supported.
 - Gunrock symbolizes the school's horse lineage and athletics identity, yet none of Gunrock's descendants remain on campus.
- Students connected to the equestrian program described the loss of varsity status as more than just a funding decision. It affects scholarships, opportunities, and is a long-standing part of campus culture.
- This moment began raising questions about how institutional priorities shape the traditions that remain visible on campus.



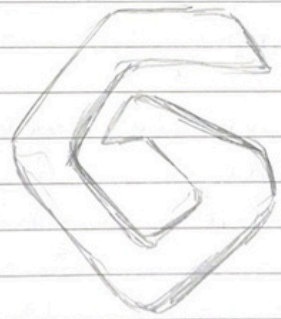
THE SILO AND GUNROCK RESTAURANT

Another location we observed was the Silo, which functions as a central dining and study space on campus. Attached to it is the Gunrock restaurant. The environment is strongly oriented toward an athletic culture. Televisions play sports content, the walls display athletic equipment, and the menu resembles typical game day food.

Interestingly, despite the restaurant being named after Gunrock, there were almost no visual representations of the horse itself. Instead, a large teddy bear sits near the entrance, which makes the identity of the space feel somewhat unclear.

Observations:

- Gunrock is more athletic oriented. It has a sports bar and TVs. The menu is fusion American, similar to game day food classics. There are sports equipment around plastered on walls. Gunrock is UC Davis athletic mascot, yet there are ~~no~~ photos or figures representing the horse. There is a large teddy bear at the entrance, which raises questions about school identity & mascot representation. The bears appear to be locally based based on the "Sudnerk" kegs laying on the ground.



Gunrock restaurant logo

In the Silo area, music makes pop style music through the speakers. The morning atmosphere is relatively calm and on the quiet side. Later in the day, the restaurant is louder. The restaurant is located in the Silo, except for Gunrock (apology professor).



- Does branding need to correlate to history?
- Coca Cola (ppl know the brand but not the history)
- Maintaining the mascot (Gunrock march, rep?)
- Why can't coexistence occur between the two entities?
- Does the mascot need to represent everyone?
 - A lot of ppl know the "blue horse" not as Gunrock
- Do both mascots need to exist for there to be polarization in school identity?
 - Pk down one to uplift the other.

STUDENT CONVERSATIONS

While at the Silo, we spoke with several students about how they perceive UC Davis identity. Many described the school as having multiple identities. Some associate Davis with veterinary science, others with agriculture, bicycles, or athletics. One transfer student described the university's identity as scattered, with horses, cows, and bikes all representing different aspects of the school.

During one conversation, a student jokingly asked, ***"Why is Gunrock wearing a compression shirt?"***

Although the comment was humorous, it opened a broader discussion about how the mascot feels strongly tied to athletics culture and hypermasculine sports imagery. Some students said the design makes Gunrock look intimidating rather than approachable.

There should also be more resources to access & transport to the center. It's much further away from campus. => Equestrian Center would gain more representation & popularity amongst Davis people => More pride, more funding.

Students seem to identify closer with the cow, whereas the school identifies w/ Cumnock more. We are known as the "Aggies" but the name does not match the identity of either mascots.

Cumnock employees ~~wear~~ wear the athletics dept logo.

* Do you think Cumnock accurately represents our school identity?

☒ YES

☐ NO

Cows more

III

IIIIII

- established

SHEEP MOWERS MURAL

Another field site we visited was the Sheep Mowers mural.

The mural presents sheep grazing lawns as a symbol of sustainability. However, UC Davis does not actually rely on sheep to maintain campus grass. Lawn mowers are used instead because they are faster and more efficient.

There are arrows shooting out to the left & right of the mural from the center (what does that symbolize?)
(> Part of me thinks that the arrows are symbolic to recycling / sustainability efforts. Since it is a sheep mural, it could be that sheep grazing is (although less effective) more environmentally friendly in the long run.

As Leon stated, the right side of the mural was completed during a colder weather, so it was likely that the dew melted off some of the paint.



Why does UC Davis consistently promote sustainability with using farm animals that they don't actually use? The school seems to fall into a performative cycle. Based on the sheep mowers talk from last week, the sheep are not actually used for their purpose of maintaining the campus lawns. The school uses actual lawn mowers instead for efficiency of time.



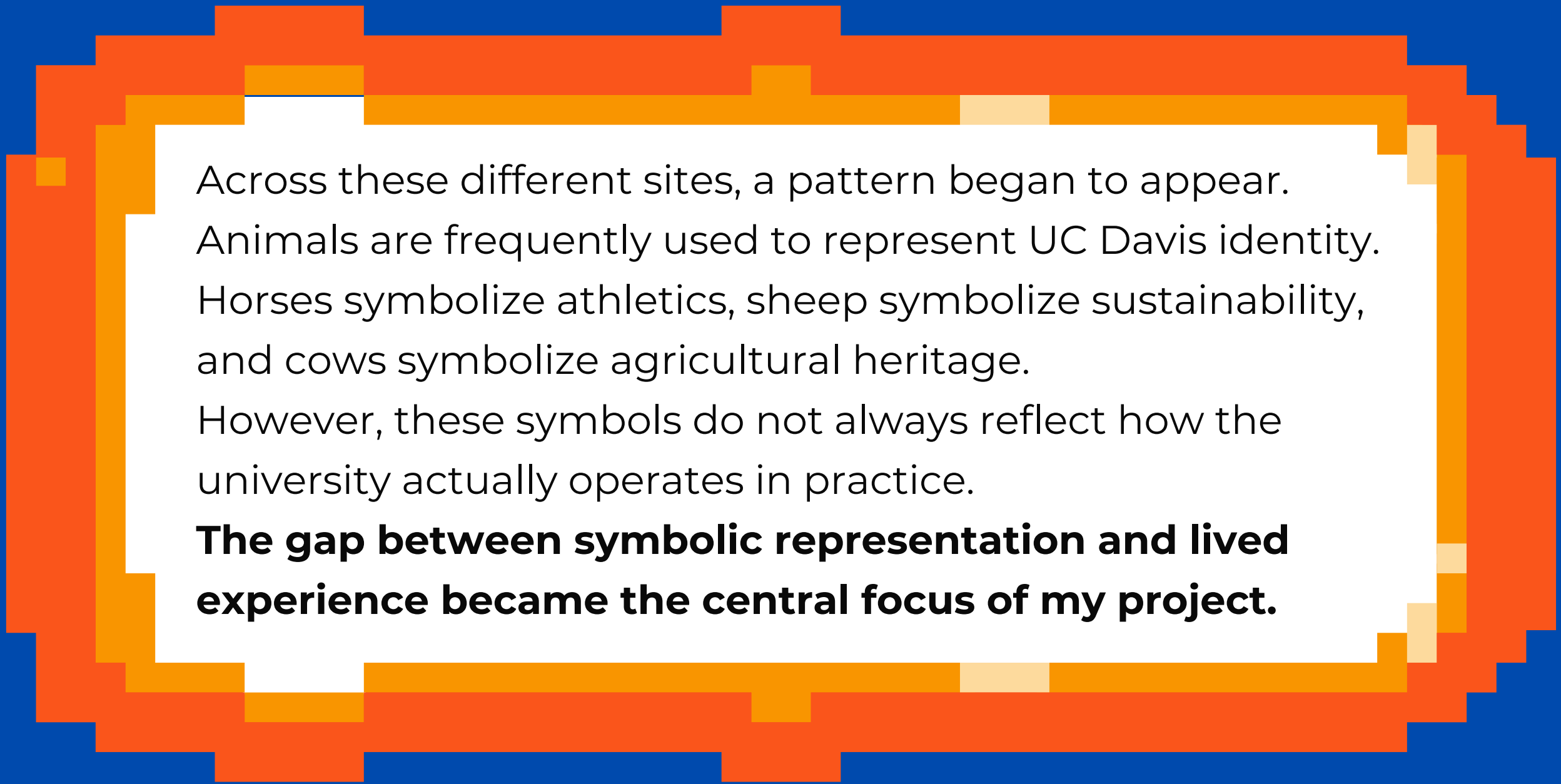
2/17
The sheep mural excludes certain animals that would allow the sheep to actually live on campus. It seems purposeful. If the mural was made for the purposes of promoting sustainability, how is it reflected in the mural. Why is the school supposedly profiting off of the sheep when there is no other sign of agriculture embedded physically on campus?
On its own, the mural is a good representation of student life: the outdoors, arboretum, turkeys, etc.

The sheep are the center of the mural, but it stems into a variety of "other" Davis iconography. Interesting disconnect? Does the mural really highlight the sheep mowers?
Most students have only seen the sheep once or twice on campus, and in those times they aren't actually grazing the lawns. Need sheep dog to expedite process? What about mowers, how will students walk on that?

Students usually only see sheep occasionally, often during exam week events meant to help with stress relief. This raised questions about why sustainability is symbolized through animals that are not actively part of everyday campus practices.

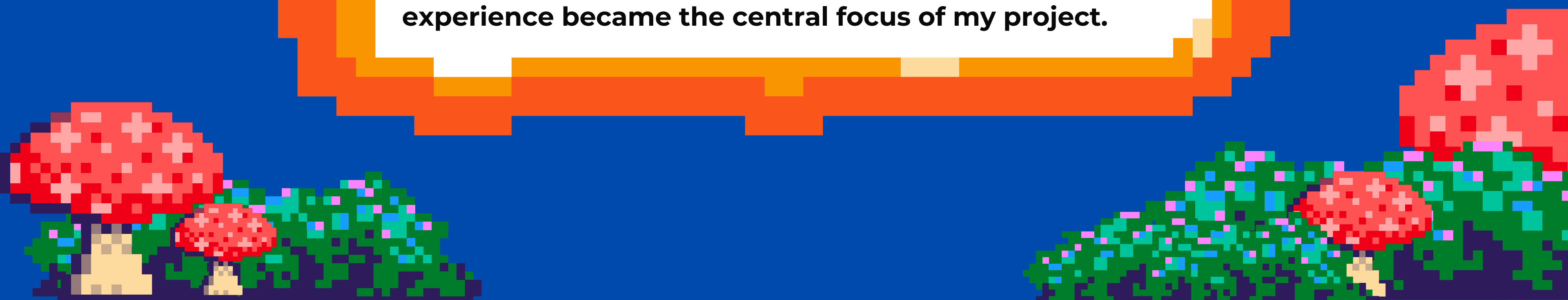


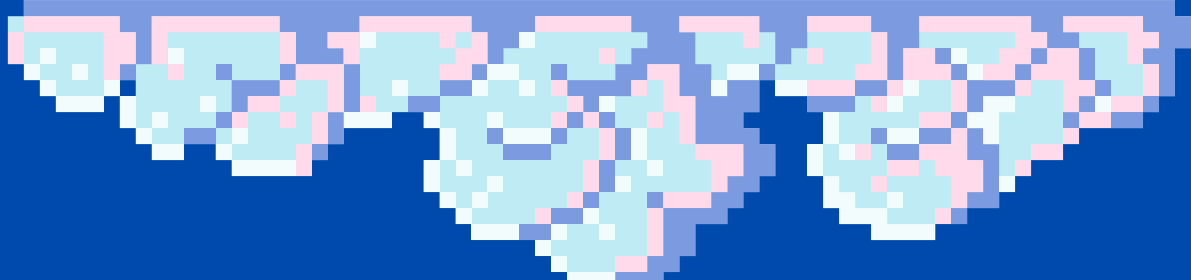
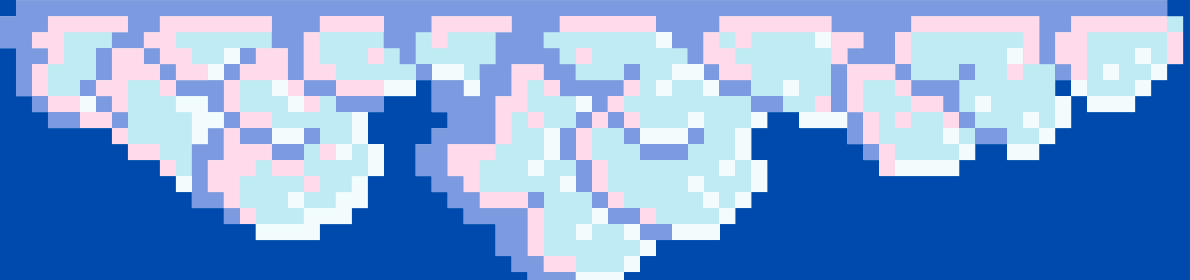
PHASE 2: EMERGING PATTERN



Across these different sites, a pattern began to appear. Animals are frequently used to represent UC Davis identity. Horses symbolize athletics, sheep symbolize sustainability, and cows symbolize agricultural heritage. However, these symbols do not always reflect how the university actually operates in practice.

The gap between symbolic representation and lived experience became the central focus of my project.





TRANSITION INTO PHASE 3

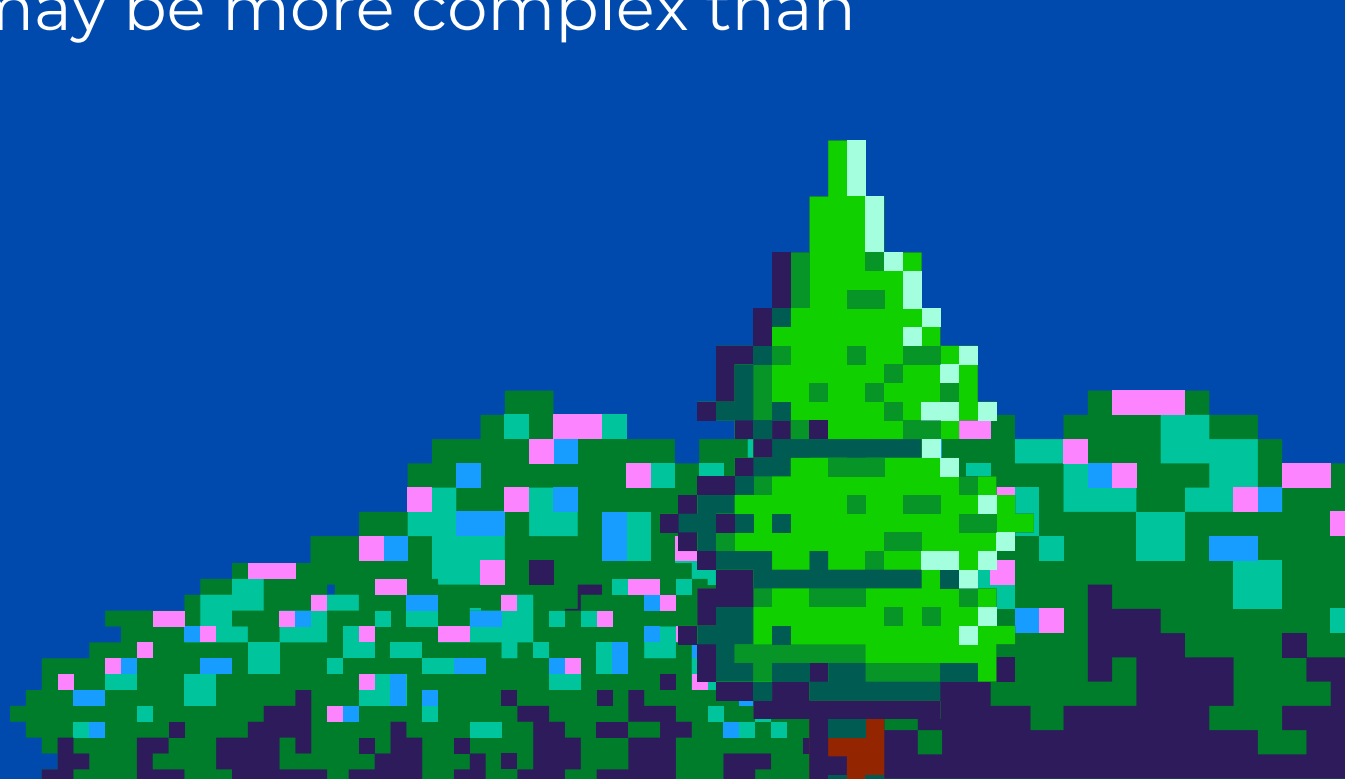
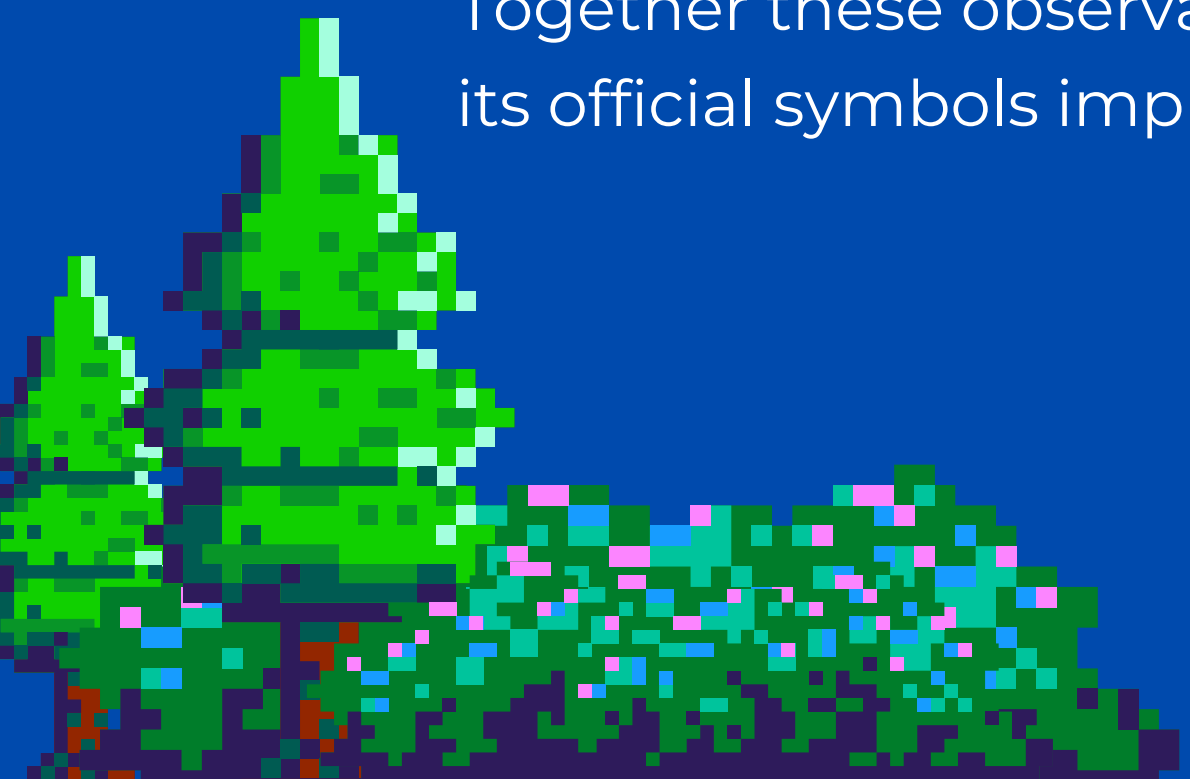
By the end of the fieldwork phase, the observations from each location began to connect.

The Equestrian Center raised questions about heritage and institutional priorities.

Conversations at the Silo revealed uncertainty about the mascot and campus identity.

The Sheep Mowers mural highlighted how sustainability imagery can exist without being fully implemented.

Together these observations suggested that UC Davis identity may be more complex than its official symbols imply.

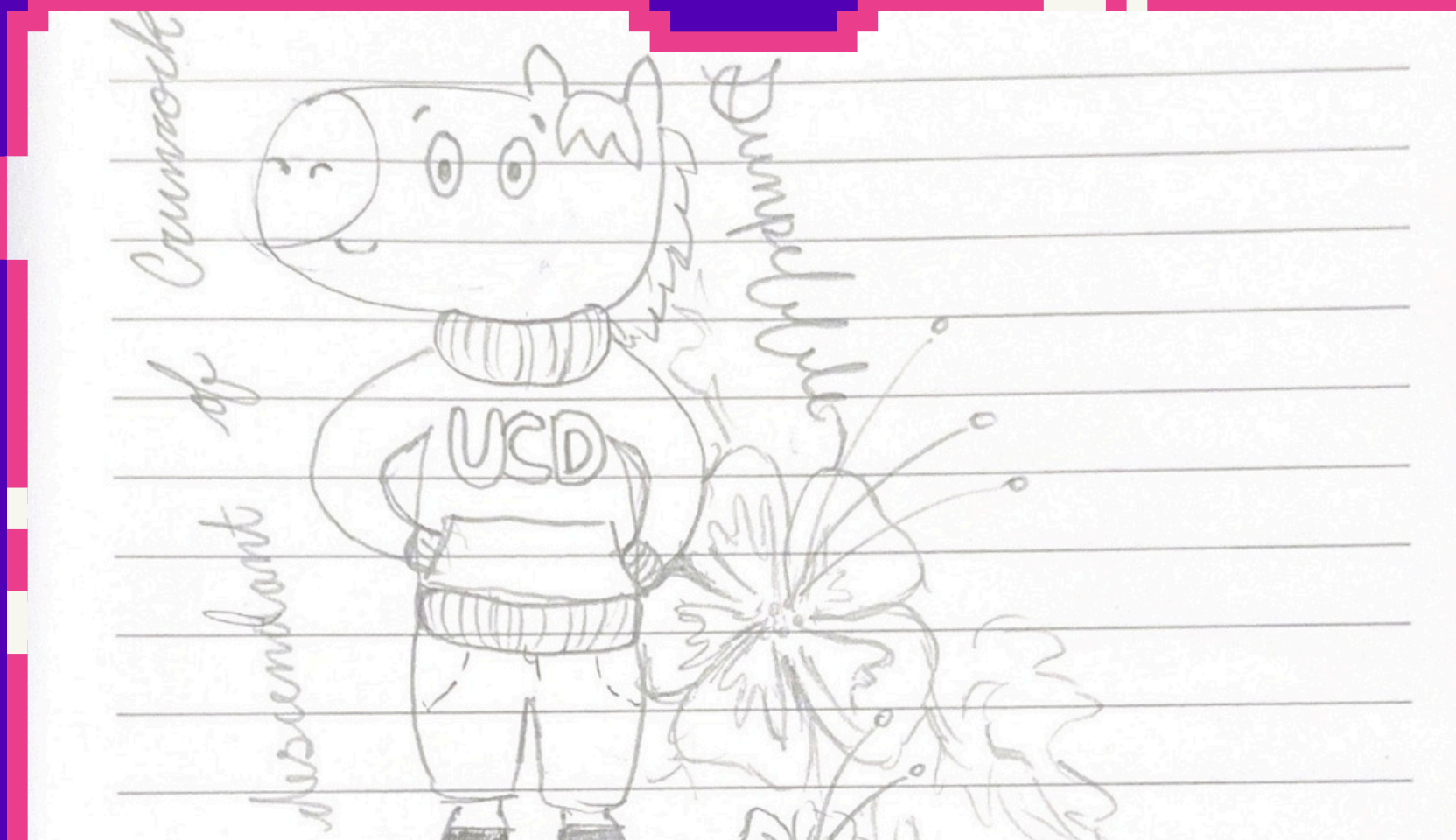


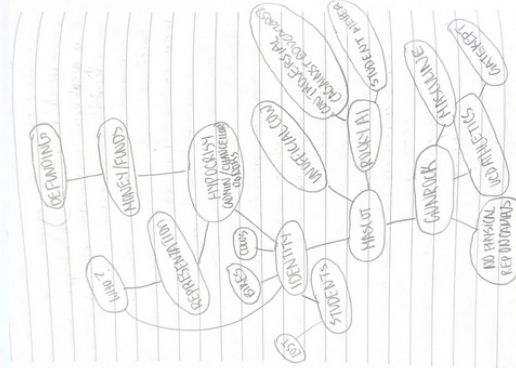
PHASE 3: PROPOSAL INTRODUCTION

My proposal is a short animated film centered on a fictional horse named Sunpebble.

Sunpebble is introduced as a descendant of Gunrock, who becomes the public face of UC Davis athletics. Because of his lineage, he is quickly elevated as a symbol of school pride.

However, Sunpebble is intentionally designed as a contradiction of Gunrock.





[Home](#) • [Sheep Shift - A Mural Celebrating UC Davis Sustainability](#)

The winning design of the Sheep Shift mural contest is being painted on the side of a temporary utility building located in central campus, west of Wickson Hall and across the street from California Hall.

Participate in Community Painting Days

Drop by on Thursday, Feb. 19 or Friday Feb. 20 between 11 a.m. and 3 p.m. to grab a paintbrush and help paint the Sheep Shift mural. Be sure to wear clothes you don't mind getting paint on!

What happens when you combine paint, poetry, campus sheepmowers, and our groundbreaking decarbonization effort? A mural contest like no other.

Even his name reflects this contrast. Sunpebble is the opposite of Gunrock. Where Gunrock sounds tough and rigid, Sunpebble sounds light, friendly, and approachable. Through this satirical design, the character becomes a representation of change.

SUNPEBBLE'S STORY



In the animated film, Sunpebble begins his role excited to represent the university. Over time, he begins noticing contradictions between the image he represents and the realities around him. He sees the equestrian program connected to his own lineage losing institutional support. He notices sustainability messaging that does not always match campus practices. He hears students express uncertainty about what the university actually represents.

When Sunpebble raises these concerns privately, he is encouraged to continue smiling and representing the brand without questioning it publicly. Eventually, he decides to leave the university and releases a public statement explaining why. The statement spreads across campus and begins circulating at other universities, prompting conversations about mascots, institutional branding, and how symbols are used to represent identity.

The film ends with a question:

Should institutions change their symbols, or should they change the systems behind them?

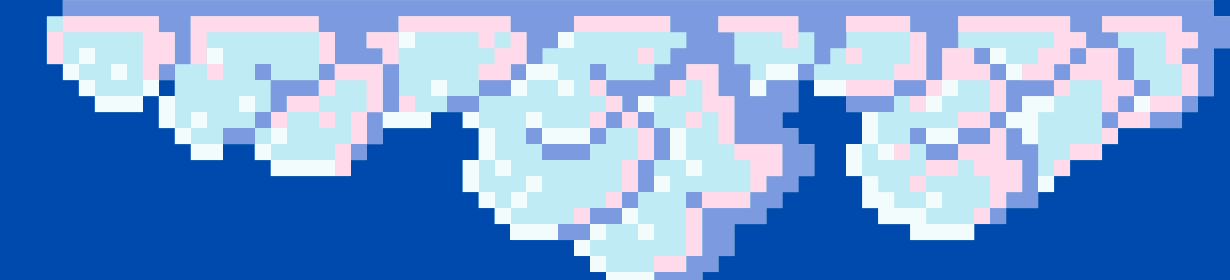
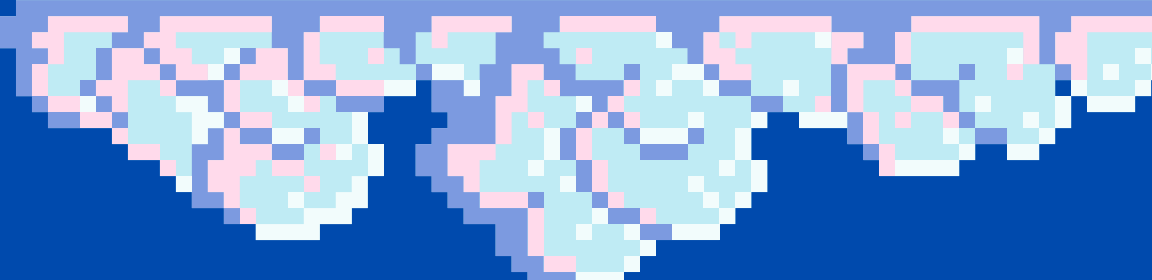


KEY TAKEAWAYS

This project helped me understand that ethnography is less about solving a problem and more about recognizing patterns in how people experience a system. Through observation and conversation, I began noticing how symbols, traditions, and institutional decisions interact in ways that are not always consistent. UC Davis contains many identities, including agriculture, veterinary science, athletics, sustainability, and student culture. Understanding how those identities are represented is a complex process.

FINAL REFLECTION

The research process did not lead to a single clear answer, but it did lead to better questions. Ethnography encouraged me to pay attention to contradictions that might normally go unnoticed. It also showed how design can be used not only to solve problems, but to start conversations. The story of Sunpebble is meant to spark those conversations. Through satire and narrative, the project invites viewers to reconsider how institutions construct identity and what those symbols truly represent.



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